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INTRODUCTION

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Digital sovereignty - Rhetoric and reality

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ABSTRACT
In recent years, the language of digital sovereignty has become ubiquitous in Europe. However, we still lack systematic knowledge if and to what extent the discourse on digital sovereignty is accompanied by actual policy change in different areas of EU policymaking. Drawing on a range of both qualitative and quantitative methods, the various contributions to this special issue examine discursive and policy change in nine major areas of EU digital policymaking. While they find policy change towards more control of the digital across all policy areas examined, this shift is only sometimes accompanied by discursive change towards digital sovereignty. This, we argue, is the result of ideational trade-offs actors face when using the language of digital sovereignty in different venues, policy areas, or countries. Considering current geo-political and geo-economic challenges, this special issue sheds light on recent transformations of EU digital policymaking and its discursive politics in the digital age.

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Introduction

Digitalisation has become a 'make-or-break issue' (von der Leyen, 2021, p. 370) for Europe. Not only does it require EU policymakers to walk a tight-rope between market-making and market-correction, between fostering digital markets and their regulation (Newman, 2020), the increasing emphasis on geo-economic and geo-political dimensions of digital policymaking has further aggravated this challenge as states increasingly seek to protect and promote their model of digital governance (Bradford, 2023; Haggart, Scholte, et al., 2021). A quarter of a century after John Perry Barlow told the world's governments that they have 'no sovereignty' (Barlow, 1996) in

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cyberspace, those very governments attempt to reassert their 'digital sovereignty' (Chander & Sun, 2021).

For long, the promotion of sovereignty seemed to be at odds with widely acknowledged core principles of a global, '"free"' Internet' (Mansell, 2011, p. 27) or the 'global information society' (Garnham, 1997), with authoritarian governments using the term as a Trojan Horse for restricting freedom of expression and opinion rights online (Flonk et al., 2020; Mueller, 2020). However, in the wake of growing concerns about issues such as disinformation (Howard, 2020), surveillance (Zuboff, 2019) and excessive market power (Khan, 2016), a (perceived) 'sovereignty gap' (Timmers, 2024, p. 572) has emerged. Democracies began to endorse digital sovereignty, in Europe in particular. In 2017, French President Emmanuel Macron advocated for a 'sovereign Europe' which would 'lead rather than undergo' the digital transformation 'by promoting its model within globalisation, a model combining innovation and regulation' (Macron, 2017). In 2019, German Chancellor Angela Merkel likewise used the term digital sovereignty. But she emphasised that sovereignty in the digital space should not be associated with closing oneself off. Instead, it should mean advocating 'a joint, free, open and secure global internet' (Merkel, 2019).

Between the laissez-faire approach established by the US and the state-controlled model in China, the EU has increasingly tried to find a distinct 'European approach' (Radu & Chenou, 2015) to regulate the Internet (Bradford, 2023). Digital sovereignty, it seems, has emerged as a guiding principle for this 'new path' (Macron, 2018) and has become '*Chefsache*' (Timmers, 2024, p. 572): Commission president Ursula von der Leyen has made it the centrepiece of her Commission's digital agenda, describing it as the 'capability that Europe must have to make its own choices, based on its own values, respecting its own rules' (von der Leyen, 2020). For Commissioner Thierry Breton, digital sovereignty is about 'Europe defending its strategic interests. Being assertive of our values. Firm in our ambitions. Confident of our means' (Breton, 2020). Employed by high-level officials, think tanks (Hobbs, 2020), and leading scholars (Floridi, 2020), the term has become a buzzword among EU policymakers (Obendiek, 2021). What are we to make of this discursive emphasis on digital sovereignty?

The academic literature has made substantial inroads into understanding the EU's discursive pivot from the language of the open and global information society to the language of digital sovereignty, approaching it from three different angles. One strand of literature discusses digital sovereignty as a policy concept, trying to assess its political usefulness and normative desirability (Mueller, 2020; Obendiek, 2021), while others have focused on a mapping of the different uses or understandings of digital sovereignty (Couture & Toupin, 2019; Hummel et al., 2021; Pohle & Thiel, 2020; Roberts et al., 2021). Another strand of literature has zeroed in on the political role

or function of digital sovereignty, seeking to 'understand what sovereignty "does"' (Barrinha & Christou, 2022, p. 361), i.e., how digital sovereignty influences the politics of digital policymaking (Bellanova et al., 2022; Broeders et al., 2023; Lambach & Oppermann, 2022). Broeders et al. (2023), for example, look at how the discourse on digital sovereignty reflects a 'geopoliticisation of digital policymaking' in the EU; Lambach and Monsees (2024) stress that digital sovereignty is not merely a regulatory project but also a geopolitical one; for Bellanova et al. (2022, p. 349) reference to digital sovereignty allows the EU, with its uncertain sovereignty status, to claim some form of sovereignty for itself.

But we still know very little whether and to what extent the discourse on digital sovereignty is accompanied by actual policy change. We lack systematic knowledge about sovereignty-related policy change in various areas of digital policy (but see Broeders et al., 2022). In other words, if digital sovereignty has become a buzzword, what is behind the buzz? Is digital sovereignty just empty rhetoric or is it accompanied by actual policy change? And conversely, is policy change towards more control of the digital always accompanied by the prominent use of digital sovereignty? Our special issue addresses these questions by covering nine key areas of EU digital policymaking: artificial intelligence policy, cloud policy, competition policy, copyright policy, digital finance regulation, external relations, industrial policy, Internet content regulation, and Internet standard-setting.

The contributions to this special issue show significant policy change in the EU. From the growing relevance of market-directing ideas in industrial (Seidl & Schmitz, 2023) and competition policy (Hoeffler & Mérand, 2023) to a 'strategic turn' in Internet standardisation (Perarnaud & Rossi, 2023) and a growing emphasis on 'public order' instead of 'free access' in the regulation of Internet content (Flonk et al., 2023), our authors identify significant changes towards more control of the digital (for details, see below). Our findings dovetail with the recent literature, which has observed a more interventionist and strategic orientation of EU digital policy (Bonnamy & Perarnaud, 2023; Broeders et al., 2023; Cini & Czulno, 2022; Heidebrecht, 2023a). Our contributors thus corroborate – across a wide range of policy areas – that the EU's broader 'geoeconomic turn' (Herranz-Surrallés et al., 2024), and 'turn towards market activism' (McNamara, 2023, p. 2) has reached digital policy.

However, there is substantial variation in how and how prominently digital sovereignty is used by relevant actors in a given policy (sub-)area. Digital sovereignty can 'pervade' (Mügge, 2024, p. 2) a policy area or be only used very sparingly (Flonk et al., 2023); it can be used to build coalitions (Seidl & Schmitz, 2023) or to drive a wedge between them (Heermann, 2023). It can be used to reinforce existing competences (Carver, 2024) or justify moves into new areas of regulation (Donnelly et al., 2023). As we discuss in more

detail below, these differences reflect policy-area-specific ideational trade-offs: whether and how actors use the language of digital sovereignty depends on costs and benefits that differ across policy (sub-) areas.

This special issue contributes to the literature in two main ways. First, it bridges the literature on EU digital policymaking and digital sovereignty by systematically analysing the relationship between discursive and policy change in key areas of EU digital policymaking. Digital sovereignty is and remains a central reference point in the EU's high-level policy discourse. For example, the recent Letta report on the Single Market views digital sovereignty as 'at the core of the common public interest' (Letta, 2024, p. 59). Given its prominence in public and policy debates, it is essential to investigate if digital sovereignty discourse leads to concomitant policy change.

Second, the special issue contributes to broader debates about the relationship between discursive and policy change, specifically in the context of the EU's 'geopoliticisation' (Herranz-Surrallés et al., 2024) and the growing entanglement between innovation and security (Haddad et al., 2024). While they cannot provide simple answers, the contributions to this special issue paint a rich picture of the costs and benefits associated with adopting the language of digital sovereignty.

Defining digital sovereignty

Digital sovereignty is an inherently ambiguous concept that different actors use in various ways (Couture & Toupin, 2019; Mueller, 2020; Pohle & Thiel, 2020; Roberts et al., 2021; Schmitz & Seidl, 2023). However, frequent usages of digital sovereignty share some core characteristics, around which various actors layer different interpretations. The core of digital sovereignty stipulates the need for *control of the digital* on the physical layer (resources, infrastructure, devices), the code layer (standards, rules, design), and the information layer (content, data) (Chander & Sun, 2021; Floridi, 2020; Sheikh, 2022). Control implies the ability to influence and restrict the manufacturing (including the mining and processing of necessary raw materials), design, use, and output of digital technologies.

In contrast to interpretations that link digital sovereignty to democratic legitimacy (Roberts et al., 2021), this definition remains agnostic as to whether control adheres to normative standards of democratic legitimacy.[1] Our conceptual focus on control is compatible with the notion of digital sovereignty promoted by diverse actors such as China and Russia and EU policymakers' (very different) understanding of the term. It also does not restrict sovereignty claims to states but, departing from traditional conceptions of sovereignty, allows different entities – and even individuals – to claim and exercise sovereignty (Bellanova et al., 2022, pp. 340–354; Pohle & Thiel, 2020, p. 11). Yet, our focus is on public actors, particularly EU institutions

and member states, who are expected and legally required to adhere to human rights and democratic norms. The relevance of these actors varies across policies and issues according to, inter alia, decision-making patterns and veto powers. Therefore, our authors examined various actors relevant to their field, such as the Commission in platform regulation and the role of the European External Action Service in digital external relations.

Beyond the core meaning of control, actors link digital sovereignty to diverse measures or instruments. States or supranational organisations can achieve control of the digital through capacity-building, investment, or regulation. The European Parliament, for example, calls for more capacity-building efforts to enhance strategic cooperation in cyber defence to strengthen resilience against cyberattacks (European Parliament, 2021). In the context of investment, the Commission's insistence on digital sovereignty has accompanied the funding of semiconductor factories to reduce strategic dependencies (Breton, 2021). In the context of regulation, pushing for Europe's digital sovereignty has been linked to fighting disinformation (Rone, 2021, p. 173) and a more general trend towards more public intervention in market activity (Heidebrecht, 2023a). These measures are not mutually exclusive and often appear together, for instance, in Europe's 'twin transition' – the green and digital transformation of the European economy (Reiners, 2021) – or in the Commission's promotion of European cybersecurity standards alongside capacity-building and investment in crucial cybersecurity infrastructures (European Commission, 2020a).

Actors may also have different goals and guiding principles. They may be motivated by a desire to protect or promote the interests or values of individuals, e.g., through the stricter enforcement of data protection standards (Madiega, 2020, p. 4). They may also aim to protect or increase the competitiveness of European companies, as exemplified by the Commission's efforts to counter the dominance of foreign firms in cloud storage (European Commission, 2020b). Finally, they may aim to protect their values, such as European 'core democratic values' (Germany's Presidency of the Council of the EU, 2020), or their strategic public interests, such as in the restriction of third-country involvement in critical infrastructure provision (Kaska et al., 2019). Therefore, what motivates the use of digital sovereignty is an empirical question analysed by the contributions to this special issue.

Research questions & conceptual framework

The contributions to this special issue are guided by three inter-related research questions:

a) Which changes in *discourse* towards digital sovereignty can be observed? Which actors claim (or negate) control gaps and demand (or reject)

various strategies towards achieving digital sovereignty, and for which reasons? Do actors acknowledge or dispute the relevance and applicability of digital sovereignty as a concept?

b) Which changes in EU *policy* towards digital sovereignty can be observed? In other words, have goals, instruments and/or settings of policies been altered towards more control of the digital?

c) What is the *relationship* between discursive and policy change? What comes first? When, how, and why (or why not) have discursive changes produced policy change?

While these questions can be answered in different ways, having a shared conceptual framework that defines what is meant by discursive and policy change is essential. For this special issue, we understand discourse as 'the representation or embodiment of ideas and […] the interactive processes by and through which ideas are generated and communicated' (Schmidt, 2011, p. 107).[2] We consider the discursive change significant if digital sovereignty is a new *central positive reference point* in the policy discourse, replacing older notions of the '"free"' Internet' (Mansell, 2011, p. 27) or the 'global information society' (Garnham, 1997). 'Central' applies when digital sovereignty is a core idea discussed by relevant policy actors when developing solutions to policy problems. It does not hold when digital sovereignty is one reference point among others. 'Positive' applies when relevance and applicability (as defined by Schmidt) are widely attributed, at least by most relevant actors, but not if digital sovereignty's relevance and/or applicability for solving policy problems is highly contested (Schmidt, 2002, p. 219).

We *exclusively focus on explicit references to digital or tech sovereignty* (including sub-concepts such as cloud or data sovereignty) or *closely related alternative terms*, such as '(open) strategic autonomy'. The rationale behind this approach is that we consider these terms equivalent. No term is uniformly perceived to be stronger or marking a more radical departure from previous discourse than another. Whether, say, 'tech' or 'digital sovereignty' or whether 'digital strategic autonomy' is used has more to do with the contingent history of a particular policy field or country than with clearly identifiable semantic differences.

In short, we argue that significant discursive change towards digital sovereignty occurs if central policy actors argue for the relevance and applicability of digital or technological sovereignty and when this concept is a core idea discussed by relevant policy actors when developing solutions to policy problems. Suppose central policy actors refer only to broader concepts that take up specific elements (possibly) linked to digital sovereignty, such as public authority, control, or security. In that case, digital sovereignty has not emerged as a relevant and applicable discursive reference point.

To conceptualise policy change, we draw on the conceptual heuristic provided by Hall (1993) and its distinction between the degree, form, or direction of steering. We consider policy change significant if there is a substantial departure in at least one of these three dimensions from the status quo ante towards more control of the digital. In many respects, the status quo ante in digital policy was a relatively hands-off approach to digital regulation that heavily relied on markets, multistakeholderism and technical expertise (ten Oever, 2021). A change towards more control would be thus a significant change in the EU's approach, with potentially far-reaching effects on global Internet governance and the geo-economic and geo-political relations of the EU (Herranz-Surrallés et al., 2024).

Drawing on Hall's framework, first-order change refers to the *degree* of steering by altering the setting of existing policy instruments. For example, compared to the 1995 Data Protection Directive, the GDPR has significantly increased fines. Typically, further experiences in implementation or new knowledge trigger adjustments that refine the existing instruments about persisting goals (Hall, 1993, p. 278). Second-order change refers to alterations in the *form* of steering by introducing new instruments. Dissatisfaction with past experiences may contribute to the rise of alternative instruments to achieve current policy goals. For example, the 2022 Digital Services Act (DSA) replaces voluntary with mandatory measures to accomplish the existing goal of restricting illegal content online (Heidebrecht, 2023b). Third-order change refers to changes in the *direction* of steering through changes in the policy goals or the prioritisation of existing goals.[3] An example is when geopolitical goals, such as limiting dependency on foreign providers, find expression in EU policies that have formerly been based on an open approach.[4]

The critical question is how do discursive and policy change relate to each other? There are, in principle, four potential combinations of discursive and policy change (see Table 1). We may observe a prominent use of digital sovereignty language in a policy sub-field with concomitant policy change in the direction of more control of the digital, which we label 'comprehensive change'. Digital sovereignty may also play a central discursive role while no policy change towards increased control exists. Under such 'rhetorical' change, there is much talk of expanding the EU's control of the digital, but no policies or policy initiatives (at least, yet) substantially promote more control of the digital. We may, by contrast, observe policy change without references to digital sovereignty or even the deliberate use of other concepts paired with a policy change that aligns with our substantive understanding of digital sovereignty as increasing control of the digital ('inconspicuous change'). Finally, the concept is absent when there is neither discursive nor policy change of a significant degree towards digital sovereignty.

It is important to stress that we are agnostic about the explanatory role of the discourse on digital sovereignty on policy change. For example, the

relationship between discourse and policy change (or continuity) could be one of ideational causation in which the arguments on digital sovereignty change the interests of policymakers and thus policy (see Blyth, 2002; Schmidt, 2002); one of strategic constructivism (see Jabko, 2006) with actors using digital sovereignty to build coalitions and legitimacy for their policy goals; or one in which the talk of digital sovereignty plays only an epiphenomenal role for the interest-based or institutional politics of policy change or continuity.

For example, Jabko (2006) has shown how EU actors strategically used the vague idea of 'the market' to rally actors with different interests behind a joint push for further European integration. However, contextual elements may also lead to 'rhetorical entrapment' when inconsistency between actions and a prevalent 'community ethos' (Schimmelfennig, 2021, p. 144) become apparent. Which of these explanatory roles is most plausible is an empirical question in our project (see also Parsons, 2016). Some of our authors point to the strategic use of digital sovereignty, specifically for coalition-building (e.g., Hoeffler & Mérand, 2023; Seidl & Schmitz, 2023). Others suggest that sovereignty frames can also be used to drive a wedge between coalitions, for example, between tech companies and civil society actors (Heermann, 2023). In other words, Table 2 serves to map empirical contributions; it does not provide a theory of why actors engage – or do not engage – in certain types of discourse or what the effects of discourse are on policy change.

Discursive change and its effects depend on context, for example, institutional settings (Schmidt, 2011, pp. 119–122) or the speaker's authority (Parsons, 2016). Of central relevance are also the agents that draw on existing and emerging ideas in different ways (Carstensen, 2011) and their embedding in, for example, epistemic communities (Haas, 1992) or advocacy coalitions (Sabatier, 1988; Sikkink, 2002). Many authors thus highlight such contextual factors when discussing the influence of discourse on policy change.

For example, some papers point to pre-existing EU competences as decisive for the relationship between discourse and policy on digital sovereignty: Shawn Donnelly et al. (2023) argue that EU officials are likely able to mobilise

Table 1. The relationship of discursive and policy change towards digital sovereignty.

	Digital Sovereignty is a central and positive discursive reference point	Digital Sovereignty is not a central and positive discursive reference point
Significant policy change towards more sovereignty	Comprehensive change	Inconspicuous change
No significant policy change towards digital sovereignty	Rhetorical change	Absence of change

alternative discourses in areas in which their authority is firmly established but rely on a more control-oriented discourse for less established security topics in the area of financial regulation. Julia Carver (2024) argues that the EU will most likely translate its discourse into concrete policy changes if pre-existing competences exist. Julia Rone (2024) points to diverging national preferences, related disputes around competences, and (limited) technological capabilities as essential factors that mediate and complicate a simple 'translation' of discourse into policy. For others, the lack of explicit references to 'digital sovereignty' shows that its discursive relevance is not necessary for policy change – though some point to strong implicit references to broadly related concepts that may be more politically acceptable (Carver, 2024; Flonk et al., 2023).

Reasserting control over the digital: the findings of this special issue

The contributions to this special issue have investigated the use of digital sovereignty discourse and accompanying policy changes in nine key areas of the EU's digital policy (see Table 2). Strikingly, all but one author finds a significant change in EU policy towards more control of the digital, present in all areas and over a relatively long period ranging from copyright (Directive adopted in 2018) to artificial intelligence (Regulation adopted in 2024).

Regarding the digital sovereignty discourse, our authors' analyses reveal that 'digital sovereignty' and closely related terms, such as strategic autonomy, are used as a central and positive reference in most areas covered. In more than half of these areas, the digital sovereignty discourse is

Table 2. Stylised overview of the findings from the special issue.

	Digital Sovereignty is a central and positive discursive reference point	Digital Sovereignty is not a central and positive discursive reference point
Significant policy change towards more sovereignty	Comprehensive change: Industrial policy (Seidl/Schmitz) Competition policy: Digital Markets Act (Hoeffler/Mérand) Internet standard-setting (Perarnaud/Rossi) AI policy (Mügge) External Relations: 5G Toolbox (Carver) Cloud policy (for the most sensitive cases) (Rone)	Inconspicuous change: Copyright policy: Copyright Directive (Heermann) External relations: Cyber Diplomacy Toolbox; external cyber capacity building (Carver) Digital finance regulation (Donnelly et al.) Content regulation (Flonk et al.)
No significant policy change towards digital sovereignty	Rhetorical change: Cloud policy (for the less sensitive cases) (Rone)	Absence of change: –

accompanied by significant policy change towards more control. More than half of the cases, thus, fit in the category of 'comprehensive change' with both discursive and policy changes present. Inconspicuous change, that is, policy change towards digital sovereignty without manifesting prior discursive change in that direction, happened (at least partially) in four areas. This reveals that even in the absence of references to digital sovereignty, EU policy in crucial areas changed significantly towards more control. None of the studied fields thus shows a complete absence of discursive and policy change. There is one case of partial rhetorical change, that is, where digital sovereignty discourse did not translate into policy change towards more control of the digital.

The extent of significant policy change across our selected digital policy areas is remarkable. Of course, our insights are limited by the bottom-up case selection from our call for papers (where authors tended to 'shoot where the ducks are'). Moreover, we miss some central cornerstones of digital policy, such as data governance, connectivity, or digital identity. However, our cases cover a broad range of issues and clearly show the EU's attempt to increase control of the digital on the physical, code, and information layers. Thus, the larger picture that emerges from the individual findings in this special issue reveals that the talk of digital sovereignty is *not* just empty rhetoric, but an important element in the broader changes of EU digital policy towards more control of the digital (see Table 2).

Catherine Hoeffler and Frédéric Mérand (2023) find a significant comprehensive change towards a more dirigiste character of EU digital policy. They focus on the Digital Markets Act as a least likely case for dirigiste influence and explain its emergence as a compromise of competing claims of control within the Commission. *Timo Seidl and Luuk Schmitz* (2023) also found such comprehensive change in EU industrial policy. Combining quantitative text analysis and qualitative document analysis as well as interviews, they show how industrial policy has undergone a 'geo-dirigiste' turn towards more actively directing markets into sectors or technologies that are deemed critical or strategic for geopolitical or geo-economic reasons.

Beyond competition and industrial policy, another critical way in which states exert control of the digital is by shaping the 'virtual infrastructure' (Haggart, Scholte, et al., 2021, p. 2) of standards and protocols on which the Internet runs. In their contribution, *Clément Perarnaud and Julien Rossi* (2023) trace the EU's growing assertiveness in influencing global Internet standard-setting processes. They analyse several legislative and non-legislative initiatives and demonstrate how the EU aims to 'promote its own vision of what the future of the Internet, as an infrastructure, should look like' (Perarnaud & Rossi, 2023, p. 4). Similarly, in his analysis of the EU's AI strategy and the recently concluded AI Act, *Daniel Mügge* (2024) finds that digital sovereignty – and what he calls AI sovereignty – plays a crucial role on both

the discursive and the policy level. While some authors find significant changes in policy and discourse across industrial policy, market regulation, Internet standards, and AI, other authors find that only some or none of the specific issue areas or policy instruments they investigate are accompanied by discursive change.

For example, in their analysis of digital finance, *Shawn Donnelly, Elena Ríos Camacho and Sebastian Heidebrecht* (2023) find significant policy change through new legislative instruments in digital finance, such as the first EU-wide regulatory framework on crypto-assets, the 2019 Markets in Crypto-Assets Regulation. While EU actors embrace more security-oriented rhetoric, particularly regarding the resilience of the critical digital financial infrastructure, significant discursive change towards digital sovereignty is mostly absent concerning crypto-assets and market infrastructure.

In her study of three cases of EU external policy, *Julia* Carver (2024) finds significant policy changes across cases. However, a significant discursive shift towards digital sovereignty, and thus *comprehensive change*, could only be observed with the 5G toolbox: a set of measures designed to respond to concerns about possible foreign interference with strategic digital technologies in the EU internal market, particularly regarding 'critical dependencies' on foreign suppliers. In cloud policy, *Julia Rone's* (2024) detailed analysis of both EU policy discourse and the positions of four important member states – Germany, France, the Netherlands, and Poland – shows how diverging national preferences, competence disputes, and (limited) technological capabilities prevented any straightforward 'translation' of digital sovereignty ambitions into policy. However, even though sovereignty provisions were ultimately limited to the most sensitive use cases, Rone still observes a 'persistence of the digital sovereignty requirements (…) despite intense opposition by member states' (Rone, 2024).

Other authors argue that digital sovereignty did not represent a significant and positive reference point in policy-related discourse, even though policy change was significant. A case in point includes *Max Heermann*'s article on copyright (2023). *Heermann* reminds his readers that the controversial EU Copyright Directive was adopted in 2019 despite resistance from a broad coalition of tech companies and civil society activists. References to digital sovereignty remained mostly implicit, making the copyright reform a case of *inconspicuous change* in our framework; yet, *Heermann's* analysis demonstrates that even implicit references to digital sovereignty can be used as a 'coalition wedge' (Seidl, 2022, p. 370) to delegitimise and ultimately break up lobbying coalitions.

In their analysis of content regulation, *Daniëlle Flonk, Markus Jachtenfuchs and Anke Obendiek* (2023) also observe such *inconspicuous change*. Analysing EU policy output from 1995 to 2021, *Flonk et al.* show that EU officials are increasingly concerned that the public order is in danger and that regulatory action in the form of increased public intervention and control is required.

Although EU institutions frame their policy decisions with regard to public order and public authority, digital sovereignty did not emerge as a central and positive reference point within their analysed timeframe.

One striking insight from our special issue is that cases of 'cheap talk', i.e., discursive use of digital sovereignty frames without significant (at least impending) policy change, are limited. However, (competence) disputes among EU institutions, diverging member state preferences, and functional necessities may well limit the extent of policy change, as we see not only in cloud policy (Rone, 2024; Adler-Nissen & Eggeling, 2024) but also in the contested nature of how exactly the EU's new industrial policy should be financed (Seidl & Schmitz, 2023), or in how strictly the EU's new content moderation or digital competition policies should or can be enforced (Flonk et al., 2023; Hoeffler & Mérand, 2023).

The (non-)Uses of digital sovereignty in discourse

While all our authors find at least some policy change towards more control of the digital, only some find that a prominent digital sovereignty discourse accompanies this policy change. This seems surprising, considering the term's central relevance for high-level officials (Breton, 2020; Hobbs, 2020; Timmers, 2024; von der Leyen, 2020). Thus, a central puzzle of our findings is posed by the variation in the policy-related discourse and the relevance of digital sovereignty therein. When does digital sovereignty emerge as a central and positive discursive reference point? And how can we explain the differences between sub-policy areas? We suggest thinking about these questions in terms of (sub-)policy-area-specific *ideational trade-offs* which actors face when invoking the notion of digital sovereignty.

On the one hand, digital sovereignty can be politically beneficial. For example, it can serve as a 'coalition magnet' (Schmitz & Seidl, 2023) that provides a common language with which actors can express their – often quite different – misgivings about the digital status quo and at least temporarily unite behind a common agenda (Lambach & Oppermann, 2022; Schmitz & Seidl, 2023). On the other hand, the language of digital sovereignty can be weaponised by internal or external actors in ways that counter the EU's interests, for example because unwelcome associations may be invoked that possibly alienate potential allies. We thus argue that whether and to what extent actors use the language of sovereignty depends on how they assess the ideational costs and benefits associated with using it.

In some policy areas, actors view it beneficial to invoke the notion of digital sovereignty in discourse. For example, for Seidl and Schmitz (2023), the rhetoric of digital sovereignty draws attention to the growing entanglement of the 'high politics' of security policy and the 'low politics' of industrial policy. This, together with its broad appeal, helped discursively orchestrate a broad

coalition in favour of a renewed industrial policy which is much more comfortable with directing resources into sectors or technologies considered 'important', 'critical' or 'strategic'. Similarly, Hoeffler and Mérand (2023) show how the concept of digital sovereignty served as a 'repertoire of ideas' which 'market-correctors', 'market-directors' and 'market-busters' could use and understand in very different ways. While digital sovereignty was only sometimes used explicitly, the 'growing priority accorded to digital sovereignty by EU leaders and the constructive ambiguity surrounding this discourse probably helped cement the [DMA] deal' (Hoeffler & Mérand, 2023, p. 17). This ultimately resulted in a more 'market-directing' digital competition policy, with 'new political and business players (…) coalescing behind dirigiste ideas long associated with France' (Hoeffler & Mérand, 2023, p. 20; cf. Bora, 2023).

The benefits of using the language of sovereignty are issue-dependent. Drawing on historical and discursive institutionalism, Donnelly et al. (2023) point to the existing legal and discursive traditions around financial stability and investor protection that enabled actors to expand control over crypto-assets and market infrastructure. In contrast, in cybersecurity, including the operational resilience of the digital financial infrastructure, digital sovereignty provided a 'central reference point to promote reforms in areas that were previously not subject to EU regulation' (Donnelly et al., 2023). Thus, in areas that expose vital vulnerabilities, such as operational resilience, EU public officials may be more likely to see benefits in referring to digital sovereignty compared to fields where they view it as more beneficial to mobilise more traditional concepts and discourses.

Strategic usage and avoidance of references to digital sovereignty are also echoed in the area of external relations, where the competences of EU institutions can clash with member state sovereignty concerns. Carver's (2024) external action cases are subject to growing geo-economic and geo-political concerns. Hence, the variation in the usage of digital sovereignty discourse suggests additional and more internal explanatory factors. Given the decisive role of Member States in EU foreign policy, the sovereignty discourse among EU institutions raises concerns among Member State representatives who are unwilling to relinquish their powers in foreign affairs. This explains why the sovereignty discourse has primarily surfaced in areas closely related to the digital single market and the EU's industrial policy, where the Commission has more competences than foreign policy.

Julia Rone (2024) also points to country-specific costs of using sovereignty language. Digital sovereignty discourse is intense in Germany and France but virtually absent in the Netherlands and Poland. The Netherlands, for example, only use the term digital sovereignty very reluctantly because, as their 2021 digitalisation strategy puts it, '*it is the standard European jargon*' (quoted in Rone, 2024). This indicates that some actors fear that emphasising the concept of digital sovereignty may result in rhetorical entrapment

(Schimmelfennig, 2001), committing them to a more interventionist agenda than they would like. Similar reservations are evident in ideological preferences in Germany and other countries, where some parties apprehend overly strong associations with protectionism or interventionism.

Such perceived ideational costs in terms of rhetorical entrapment or rhetorical estrangement may spur actors to rely on closely related but alternative terms, and digital sovereignty is not always the only, or even preferred, concept. Carver (2024, p. 21, p. 23) argues that digital sovereignty in external relations is, in many respects, 'indistinguishable' or 'indistinctive' from and often replaced by similar concepts, such as 'strategic autonomy'. Similarly, Rone shows how the Dutch government prefers the term digital autonomy, as it considers it 'easier to reconcile with a more liberal, business-led approach' (Rone, 2024, p. 12). Carver's analysis also shows that interviewees fear referring to the concept as it 'could be "misunderstood" as a guise for imperialism, colonialism and "traditional" geopolitics' (Carver, 2024, p. 24).

This might be one of the reasons that many of our authors find that neither digital sovereignty nor closely related terms feature prominently in the discourse. For example, in content regulation, *Flonk et al*. (2023) find references to broader concepts, such as control, public authority, and the public interest, but only few examples that link key initiatives, such as the Digital Services Act or the Terrorist Content Regulation, to digital sovereignty explicitly. In the copyright case, digital sovereignty was used in the policy debate but competed with similar, more established frames (Heermann, 2023). One reason is the Directive's early adoption date in April 2019 compared to other policies in our special issue, as the digital sovereignty discourse became more robust with the start of the von der Leyen Commission in December 2019. However, there may be additional reasons for the gap between the high-level use of the concept and actual policy-related discourse in some areas.

Other contributors reflect on the potential contradictions and shortcomings of using digital sovereignty. *Perarnaud and Rossi* (2023) show how standard setting became a 'key priority in the EU digital sovereignty agenda' but also argue that this strategic turn comes with several inconsistencies. In its attempts to take on a more assertive role in Internet governance under the banner of digital sovereignty, the EU inadvertently carries discursive water for a state-centred vision of Internet standardisation that runs counter to its (at least, earlier) advocacy of an open Internet. Through a critical analysis of programmatic texts, *Mügge* (2024) shows that the prominent use of the language of digital sovereignty has proved entirely compatible with an economistic and Eurocentric AI policy. It prioritises pitting the EU against other major AI powers, rather than citizens against Big Tech; it aims to boost the EU's position in a putative AI race rather than defying a logic of competition and competitiveness; and it is primarily meant to benefit European actors, rather than embracing a more global viewpoint and responsibility. *Mügge*

thus uncovers an often-neglected tension between the EU's emphasis on human-centred AI and the fact that the EU's AI policy reflects a strong focus on economic competitiveness but largely ignores the global ramifications of the EU's attempt to join the US and China in the race for AI.

Conclusion

Writing in 2024, it is evident that the notion of digital sovereignty (as well as related concepts like strategic autonomy) has become commonplace in Brussels. The contributions to our special issue demonstrated that digital sovereignty is not cheap talk but that the EU is significantly moving in key digital policy areas towards more control. None of our authors find that digital sovereignty is only empty rhetoric, unaccompanied by policy change towards more control of the digital on the physical, code, and information layer (cf. Sheikh, 2022). Instead, all authors observe at least some and often significant policy change in recent years, confirming scholarship on the intensity and discontinuity of recent EU digital policymaking (e. g. Bonnamy & Perarnaud, 2023; Broeders et al., 2023; Cini & Czulno, 2022; Heidebrecht, 2023a). They also point out that the language of digital sovereignty is not always employed, or employed equally, across venues, policy sub-areas, and countries or employed without contestation.

We have argued that to understand whether policy change is accompanied by discursive change, it is helpful to zero in on the ideational trade-offs actors face when using the language of digital sovereignty. While several contributions focus on the benefits of digital sovereignty as a coalition-building discursive device, others highlight the costs of using it given that it can evoke unwanted associations that 'estrange' others or rhetorically 'entrap' (Schimmelfennig, 2021) actors in ways that limit their future policy leeway. Depending on how they navigate these trade-offs, actors might be more comfortable using the language of sovereignty when formulating a broader policy agenda rather than hashing out the details of specific policies (Flonk et al., 2023; Hoeffler & Mérand, 2023). Similarly, actors may be more at ease with using digital sovereignty when justifying their move into new policy areas or the use of fundamentally new economic ideas compared to when they operate in areas of established competence or want to continue existing policy traditions (Donnelly et al., 2023; Hoeffler & Mérand, 2023; Seidl & Schmitz, 2023). Lastly, protagonists may hesitate to speak about digital sovereignty due to normative considerations; consider that some of our authors pointed to contradictions between the EU's professed values and the potential economistic, state-centred, and Euro-centric connotations of sovereignty (Mügge, 2024; Perarnaud & Rossi, 2023).

Together, the contributions to this special issue illuminate a policy change towards more control of the digital and the 'rhetorical

performativity' (Bellanova et al., 2022, p. 348) of digital sovereignty discourses, i.e., their variegated role in the discursive politics of recent EU digital policymaking. The universe of possible cases is, of course, more extensive, with digital sovereignty potentially also shaping, among others, space policy, infrastructure policy (Musiani, 2022), including submarine cables, data governance (see also Blancato, 2024), semiconductor policy, research policy, taxation, or flagship projects such as Destination Earth. Future research should, however, not only expand on the empirical scope of our special issue but look at other policy areas in which digital technologies and geo-political or geo-economic dynamics are increasingly central (cf. Broeders et al., 2023). It should also look beyond agreed-upon policies and at their actual implementation: Does the EU's attempt to regain control of the digital live up to its ambition, or does it get bogged down in implementation, financing and enforcement issues? Moreover, future studies should further theorise and analyse the contextual factors that shape the costs or benefits of using the language of digital sovereignty. Lastly, future research should look at whether the policies the EU adopts in the name of digital sovereignty further the various goals actors associate with it, from economic competitiveness to geopolitical security to the assertion of rights and values in an increasingly digital world.

Notes

1. Legitimacy might nonetheless – in the Weberian sense – increase the effectiveness of control. Crucially, however, despite different motivations, measures and interpretations, the logic of control differs from the rights-centred legitimacy logic of human rights discourse as well as from the efficiency logic of market discourse. To what extent these three logics of (i) control, (ii) economic efficiency, and (iii) rights-based legitimacy (or other logics) challenge, replace, and co-exist with each other in specific policy areas, is an empirical question.
2. For stylistic purposes, we sometimes use the term rhetoric rather than discourse. However, we use these terms interchangeably.
3. One problem of the conceptual assumptions of Hall's framework is that it associates third order change with a Kuhnian 'paradigm shift' (1970). However, the concept of paradigm remains underspecified in the original article and underestimates the iterative character of incremental change (Hay, 2001). We therefore distinguish the notion of a change in policy goals and the introduction of new goals from a fully-fledged paradigm shift that features change in the overarching level of ideas behind policy (Falkner, 2016, p. 224).
4. Importantly, we propose using Hall's heuristic pragmatically to categorise different types of change but do not adopt the broader conceptual assumptions of Hall's framework. For example, Hall suggests that a higher level of change automatically implies change on the lower levels, but we consider this an empirical question. It should also be noted that a higher 'order' of change does not necessarily indicate more significant change. First-order change can, at times, be more radical than second-order change. For instance,

the heavy increase in fines in the GDPR constituted a significant change compared to an entirely new policy instrument that might have been 'without teeth'.

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